

NERAI QUESTION REPORT · FORWARD OUTLOOK · 23 OCTOBER 2026

US–Iran: the pause before the second round

What happens next between Washington, Jerusalem and Tehran over the next six months: strikes, timing, coalition, Iran's answer, and what it means for Hormuz, the Red Sea and energy.

NATURE	STRIKE ROUND BY 23 APR 2027	MOST LIKELY WINDOW	HORMUZ, NEXT 6 MONTHS
Material conflict risk	Most likely	4–30 Nov 2026	SEVERE

Cover: the Gulf at night from the International Space Station (NASA Earth Observatory, public domain). Data as of 23 Oct 2026 (GDELT to 22 Oct).

The calls

The war has paused, not ended. NERAI expects the United States and Israel to open a second, short and intense strike round on Iran after the 3 November US vote, most likely in the second half of November. Iran will answer sideways, against Gulf energy, US bases and shipping, rather than in kind. By the new year the conflict most likely settles back into blockade, a tanker war and talks through Qatar and Pakistan.

Our pair models read the last 30 days between the US and Iran as words without matching action: threats and force are both below the pair's own wartime year. That is the pre-election lull the White House promised, not a de-escalation. Force posture, dated war plans and the sea campaign around Hormuz point the other way. The strongest model signal is economic: new sanctions designations against Iran are **high** for the coming month, and Iran's interstate military escalation reading is **high**.

#	Question	NERAI verdict
1	**How does US–Iran tension evolve?**	**Material conflict risk** in every horizon. 30 days: high (second strike round). 90 days: elevated (back to blockade and tanker war). 12 months: elevated (no settlement; an interim Hormuz-for-blockade swap at best).
2	**Will Israel and/or the US strike Iran by 23 Apr 2027?**	**Yes, most likely.** A joint US–Israeli opening, US-led, in the first weeks after 3 November; a few days of air and missile strikes on energy and petrochemical export sites, buried nuclear sites (Pickaxe Mountain, Isfahan) and missile and drone stocks.
3	**Do ground forces play a role?**	**Boots on decks, not on the ground.** Boarding and seizure of blockade-runners continues; a special-forces raid on enriched-uranium sites or a seizure of Kharg is a tail risk, not the plan.
4	**Do Gulf states, Azerbaijan and Türkiye support the coalition?**	**Quiet enablers, loud mediators.** Saudi Arabia grants airspace and air defence; the UAE is the most forward; Bahrain, Kuwait and Qatar host but avoid offensive roles; Oman, Türkiye and Azerbaijan stay out.
5	**How does Iran respond?**	**Horizontal, not proportional.** Missiles and drones at Israel and US bases within hours; then Gulf energy, data and cable sites; peak Hormuz attacks and mining; the Houthis widen fire. An NPT withdrawal notice becomes a live option if buried nuclear sites are hit.
6	**What happens at the chokepoints?**	**Hormuz SEVERE** throughout; **Bab el-Mandeb DISRUPTED**, with Suez's container return the first casualty of a new round; Brent back toward its April peak zone during strikes; war-risk cover stays near its highs.
7	**How does escalation unfold, and what stops it?**	Five rungs from today's tanker war to a nuclear threshold; NERAI expects rungs 1–2 in November and a slide back to rung 0 by January. Off-ramps run through Doha, Islamabad and the new R4+E4 track in Istanbul.

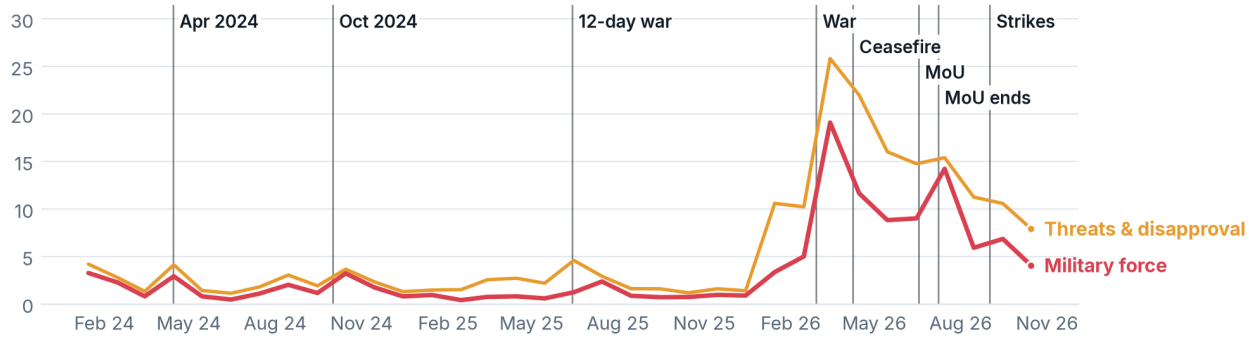
Bands are NERAI's composite outlook (event forecasts, GDELT signals against each pair's own record, stated positions, force posture, the calendar and past episodes). Bands and driver words only; named forecasts are those that pass NERAI's strict benchmark.

Where things stand on 23 October

- **The war.** The US and Israel opened the war on 28 February 2026. A ceasefire on 8 April led to the Islamabad memorandum, signed on 17 June; it collapsed on 8 July after Iranian attacks on ships in Hormuz. The US reinstated its naval blockade of Iranian ports, and strikes resumed in early September [1][2].
- **The pause.** On 8 October President Trump said there would be no strikes before the 3 November midterms [3][10]; the White House repeated it on 22 October: "The United States will not be attacking Iran at any time prior to the midterm elections" [3][4].
- **The plans.** US and Israeli militaries have drawn up plans for "a short but intensive operation" after the midterms, with energy infrastructure, nuclear sites including Pickaxe Mountain, and missile and drone arsenals as likely targets; jets have rehearsed over Iraq and Defence Secretary Hegseth met Prime Minister Netanyahu in Israel this week [4][5]. A person briefed on the planning told NPR that Israel wanted to strike in mid-October and that Trump objected [6].
- **The sea.** October is the worst month of the war for shipping: 27 attacks on merchant ships to 22 October, according to the IMO, against 22 in March [7]. Iran's Revolutionary Guards said seven tankers were hit on 21–22 October; Washington called the claims fabricated [8].
- **The threats.** Iran's security chief Mohsen Rezaei said Iran would hit oil facilities, undersea cables, data centres and AI sites in up to seven Gulf countries if attacked again; the IRGC announced an "offensive" doctrine [9][10].
- **The squeeze.** The rial has passed 2.6 million to the dollar on the open market and the central bank is selling reserves to defend it [11]. CENTCOM says the blockade has kept $25 billion of crude from export [1].
- **The talks.** Indirect contacts continue through Qatar and Pakistan; Iran's seven-day plan (reopen Hormuz against an end to the blockade, sanctions relief and frozen assets) stays on the table [10][9].

US–Iran military activity in October runs well below its wartime average, yet about 5 times the 2025 level

Events between the US and Iran per 1,000 events worldwide, monthly, both directions; October to date



Source: NERAI on The GDELT Project CAMEO events (gdeltproject.org) · Data cut-off 22 Oct 2026 · NERAI

What NERAI's own record shows: the lull is real. Military events between the two in October run well below their wartime average, yet still several times the 2025 level. NERAI's pair reading for the last 30 days is "rhetorical tension without matching action". We read it as a pause decided in Washington, not a turn toward peace.

1 · How the tension evolves: 30, 90 and 365 days

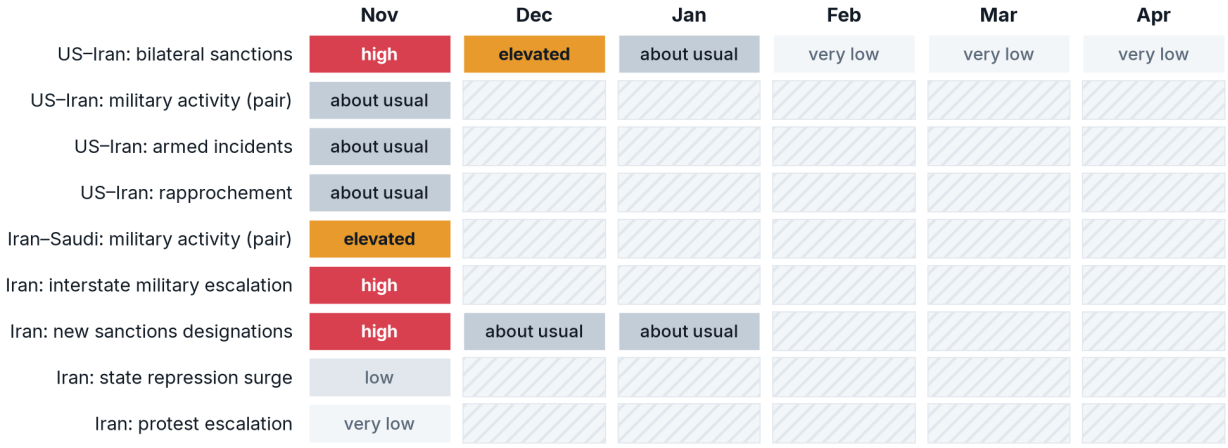
Classification: material conflict risk. This is not rhetoric and not a diplomatic rupture. The two sides have been at war for eight months, the blockade is in force and the October lull is a political pause tied to an election date.

Horizon	Band	What most likely happens	Main drivers
Next 30 days (to 22 Nov)	high	Quiet on Iranian soil until 3 November; a joint US–Israeli strike round in the following two to three weeks; Iranian retaliation across the Gulf.	White House pledge expires with the vote; build-up due to be complete by early November [9]; Iran's interstate escalation reading high; sanctions designations high.
Next 90 days (to 21 Jan)	elevated	After a few days of strikes, a return to blockade, tanker attacks and mediated talks; a second, smaller round possible before the new Congress sits on 3 January.	"Short but intensive" plan design [5]; blockade sustainable "for the foreseeable future" [7]; lame-duck window.

Next 12 months	elevated	No comprehensive settlement. An interim swap (Hormuz reopened against the blockade lifted and frozen assets released, uranium diluted or exported) is the most likely way out, not before the first quarter of 2027.	Enriched uranium unresolved since the June memorandum [12]; Iran's economy under acute strain; Gulf mediators active.

NERAI models: sanctions pressure is the strongest signal; force between the US and Iran reads as a pause

Named (benchmark-passing) forecasts by month, bands vs the panel; month one = 23 Oct-22 Nov; hatched = not forecast at this range



Source: NERAI event forecasts (GDELT, UCDP, OFAC/EU/UK/UN registers, Wikidata) · Data cut-off 21 Oct 2026 (GDELT); forecasts as of 23 Oct 2026 · NERAI

NERAI models by month (month one is 23 Oct–22 Nov). Only benchmark-passing forecasts are shown. The US–Iran pair targets read "about usual" for force: the lull. The country-level escalation reading for Iran and the sanctions rows carry the signal. Iran–Saudi military activity is elevated, driven by the Houthi war on Saudi Arabia.

2 · Will they strike, who first, what and how

Verdict: yes. A second US–Israeli strike round on Iran before 23 April 2027 is NERAI's base case, most likely in November 2026.

- **Who first.** A joint opening, US-led. Israeli sources told ABC News the decision is "only for Trump to decide" and that even a unilateral Israeli strike would need US consent [4]. Israel will not move first on its own before its government is formed; Netanyahu would prefer Iran to fire first [9].
- **What.** Energy and petrochemical export infrastructure (to squeeze the economy and force concessions), deeply buried nuclear sites including Pickaxe Mountain and the Isfahan tunnels, missile and drone production and launchers, IRGC naval assets [5][4].
- **How.** A short, intense campaign of a few days: carrier and land-based aviation, standoff missiles, cyber operations, with the blockade kept in place. The US is concentrating three carriers, an extra amphibious group and roughly 9,000 additional sailors and Marines in the region [1][9][13].
- **What it is not.** Not a regime-change ground war. Netanyahu has pledged to topple Iran's government [10]; Washington's is a better deal. The gap between the two decides how long the round lasts.

Timing: when, if strikes happen

Window	Band	Why	Known dates (markers, not forecasts)
A · Pre-election to 3 Nov	low	Public White House pledge [3][4][10]; Trump objected to an Israeli strike planned for mid-October [6]. The exception is a mass-casualty Iranian strike on US forces, which would bring an immediate response.	27 Oct Israeli election · 3 Nov US midterms · 4 Nov anniversary of the 1979 embassy seizure
B · Post-election and lame duck 4 Nov–early Jan	high (peak 4–30 Nov)	Pledge lapses; build-up complete; Israeli caretaker government keeps full war powers while coalition talks run [14][15]; IAEA Board gives a nuclear peg; acting before a possibly hostile Congress sits favours November and December [9].	4 Nov Israeli results · 10 Nov Knesset sworn in · 16–20 Nov IAEA Board [16] · 9 Dec (23 Dec with extension) first coalition deadline [17] · 3 Jan new Congress; Soleimani anniversary

C · Feb–Apr 2027	elevated	The fallback window if November slips or the first round brings no talks; a trigger window if Iran moves on the NPT or uranium. Ramadan is no bar: the war began on 28 February, during Ramadan.	8 Feb Ramadan begins · 11 Feb Revolution anniversary · 28 Feb war anniversary · early Mar IAEA Board · 20 Mar Nowruz

Strike risk peaks in November, after both elections; Hormuz stays hot every month

Six-month risk calendar, likelihood bands by month (words only); late October = 23-31 Oct

	to 3 Nov	post-election / lame duck			Feb–Apr 2027		
	Late Oct	Nov	Dec	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr
Major US–Israeli strike round on Iran	low	HIGH	elevated	elevated	elevated	elevated	guarded
Iranian fire on Gulf energy, US bases	guarded	HIGH	elevated	guarded	guarded	elevated	guarded
Hormuz ship attacks and mining	HIGH	HIGH	HIGH	elevated	elevated	elevated	elevated
Houthi fire: Saudi Arabia and Red Sea	HIGH	HIGH	elevated	elevated	elevated	elevated	guarded
Hezbollah–Israel front reopens	guarded	elevated	guarded	guarded	guarded	guarded	guarded
Iranian nuclear move (NPT notice)	low	elevated	elevated	guarded	guarded	elevated	guarded
Interim Hormuz-for-blockade deal	low	low	guarded	guarded	elevated	elevated	elevated
Known dates (markers, not forecasts)	27 Oct Israel vote 3 Nov US vote	4 Nov result (IL) 16-20 Nov IAEA	9-23 Dec Israeli coalition deadline	3 Jan new US Congress	8 Feb Ramadan 28 Feb anniversary	Early Mar IAEA 20 Mar Nowruz	Spring IRGC drill season

Source: NERAI analysis of event forecasts (event-live-v9), GDELT signals, stated positions and force posture; dates: IAEA, Knesset, US Congress · Data cut-off 23 Oct 2026 · NERAI

If no strike comes: the most likely path, month by month

Month	Most likely course without a strike round
November	Trump holds after a bruising midterm; the blockade stays; a fresh wave of US designations (NERAI: high); Hormuz attacks stay at October's pace; the IAEA Board keeps Iran's file at the Security Council and Iranian MPs push the NPT bill.
December	Doha- and Islamabad-mediated drafting on an interim swap; Houthi–Saudi fighting on Yemen's west coast; Israel's coalition talks absorb Jerusalem; occasional US strikes on Iranian boats and launch sites near the strait.
January	The new Congress raises war-powers and cost pressure in Washington; Iran's fuel and cash squeeze peaks; Soleimani anniversary rhetoric; a pressure peak that tests both sides' patience.
February	Ramadan and the Revolution anniversary; the most likely month for a first interim deal: partial reopening of Hormuz against blockade relief and access to frozen assets.
March	Implementation fights over uranium dilution and inspections at the March IAEA Board; the war anniversary hardens positions; Nowruz pause.
April	Either a working interim arrangement and slow traffic recovery in Hormuz, or a renewed strike decision as the spring drill season opens.

3 · Ground forces: boots on decks, not on the ground

- **Certain and ongoing: maritime seizures.** Marines of the 31st Marine Expeditionary Unit have boarded tankers trying to run the blockade; US forces have redirected and disabled blockade-runners [7][18].
- **Tail risk: raids.** Options under discussion since March include a special-forces operation against highly enriched uranium buried at Isfahan and a seizure of Kharg Island, Iran's main export terminal [19][20]. Kharg has been struck, not seized [18]. Any raid would mean US troops holding ground under fire, which explains the reluctance [20].
- **Not on the table: invasion.** No pre-positioning consistent with a ground campaign has been reported; the build-up is air, naval and amphibious.
- **Watch for:** airborne units moving into Gulf staging bases, special-operations aircraft surges at Gulf bases, and Iranian claims of captured personnel.

4 · Will the region help this time? Country by country

Country	Basing	Overflight	Intelligence	Air defence	NERAI call
Saudi Arabia	Defensive and support only	Likely yes	Yes	Yes, integrated	**Quiet enabler.** The US needs Saudi airspace and sent an extra Patriot battery for a key oil site to secure it [21]. Riyadh is already at war with the Houthis and leads R4 diplomacy in public.
UAE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes, with Israeli systems	**Most forward.** Hit hardest (over 2,800 projectiles in seven weeks) and prefers a conclusive outcome; reportedly hosts an Israeli-operated Iron Dome [22][23].
Qatar	Hosts US command at Al Udeid	Restricted	Yes	Yes	**Host and mediator.** Lobbied against energy strikes in August; keeps the US–Iran channel open [21] [10].
Bahrain	Yes (Fifth Fleet)	Yes	Yes	Yes	**Full host,** little choice; security crackdown at home [23].
Kuwait	Logistics and defence	Limited	Yes	Yes	**Host, low profile.** Over 1,200 projectiles absorbed; acts through the GCC rather than alone [22].
Oman	No	No	Limited	Own defence	**Stays out;** mediator and Hormuz neighbour, publicly opposed to strikes [24][23].
Türkiye	No (Incirlik barred)	No	NATO channels	NATO missile defence only	**Non-belligerent.** Ankara says its air, land and sea space will not be used against Iran; it backs Saudi defence against the Houthis through the Mecca pact and hosts the R4+E4 talks [25][26][27].
Azerbaijan	No	No	Not public	Own defence	**Stays out.** President Aliyev: Azerbaijan "neither participated nor will participate in any operations against Iran" [28].

Iraq is no longer a host: the last US troops left on 30 September, and the main Iran-aligned militias suspended attacks [29].

5 · Iran's answer

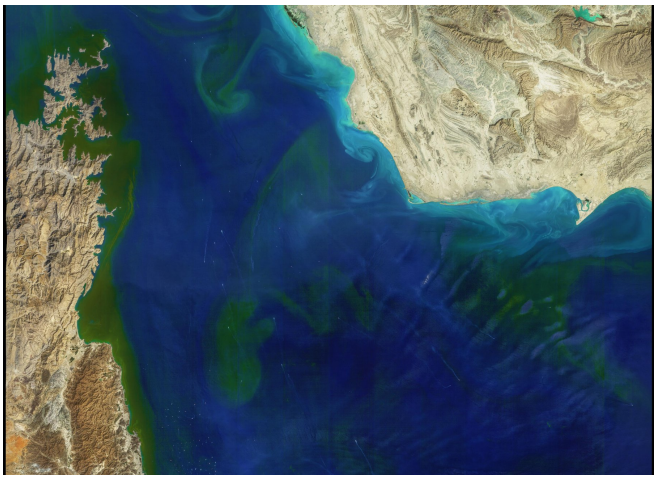
Channel	NERAI call	Timing and form
Missiles and drones on Israel	certain	Within hours of the first strikes; mixed salvos. Iran claims a larger, more precise stockpile than in June 2025 [10].
US bases	very likely	Bahrain, Kuwait, Jordan, the UAE and Qatar; the IRGC has warned that escort operations alone could bring this on [8].
Gulf energy and digital infrastructure	likely	Explicit threat list: oil, cables, data centres, AI sites in up to seven countries [9]; precedent: the March strike on Ras Laffan [23]. States lending airspace come first.
Hormuz harassment and mining	certain	Already at a wartime peak; expect the strike days to bring the most intense week of the war at sea, and attacks at anchorages outside the strait.
Houthis	likely	Already at war with Saudi Arabia; the risk is that targeting widens from Saudi-linked to US-, Israel- and all Western-linked shipping in the Red Sea.
Iraqi militias	elevated	Resumption at low level against Kurdistan, Jordan, Kuwait and Saudi Arabia from Iraqi soil; their pause is conditional [29].
Hezbollah	guarded	Rebuilding and engaged in talks on its disarmament; limited fire in solidarity, not a full front [30][31].
Nuclear move	elevated	A bill to leave the NPT is before parliament, and the enriched-uranium stock is the main sticking point in talks [32][12]. A strike on buried sites makes an NPT notice a live option; continued ambiguity over the stockpile is the base case.

6 · The chokepoints

Strait of Hormuz: SEVERE (NERAI status, floor set on 20 October). The Joint Maritime Information Center rates the strait SEVERE and the Arabian Gulf SUBSTANTIAL [33]. Lloyd's List counted 104 non-Iran-linked transits in the week to 11 October [7]. War-risk cover for a transit costs roughly thirty times its pre-war rate [35]. During a strike round, expect the most intense week of attacks and mining claims of the war, and ship-to-ship transfer zones and anchorages to be hit.

Bab el-Mandeb and Red Sea: DISRUPTED. The Houthi blockade on Saudi-linked shipping has been in force since 20 July; Saudi-backed forces retook ground around the strait in early October [33][36]. Suez traffic was still well below pre-2023 levels in September [37], yet container lines are returning fast; a new round would stop that return first [38].

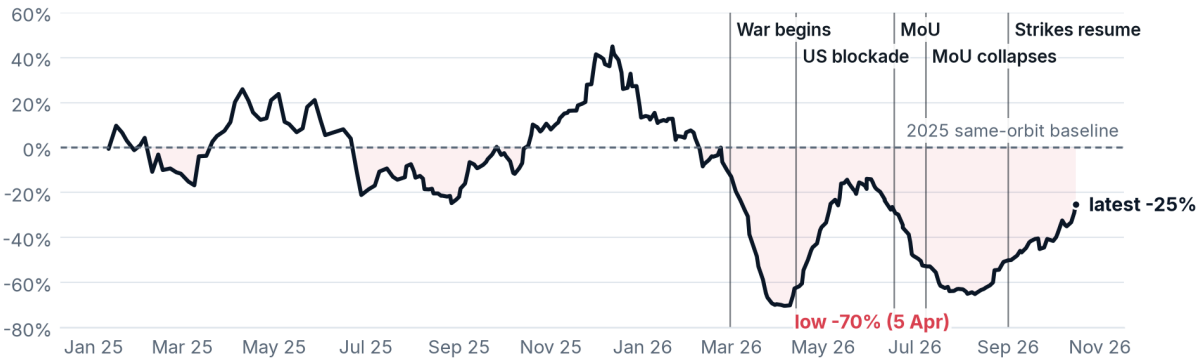
Energy. Brent spot was $115 on 20 October, against $71 on the eve of the war and a $138 peak on 7 April [39]. A strike round pushes prices back toward the April peak zone for days; the speed of the relief depends on whether Gulf export sites are hit.



The Strait of Hormuz from Landsat 8 (NASA Earth Observatory, public domain).

Radar still sees fewer ships in the strait: the 30-day average is 25% below the 2025 baseline

Vessels detected per 1,000 km² of water imaged vs the same orbit's 2025 median, 30-day mean (presence, not transits)



Source: NERAI Sentinel-1 SAR vessel presence, Strait of Hormuz; contains modified Copernicus Sentinel data 2025–2026 · Data cut-off 16 Oct 2026 · NERAI

Brent trades about $44 above its pre-war level and has eased since mid-October

US dollars per barrel, daily



Source: U.S. Energy Information Administration, Brent spot FOB (public domain) · Data cut-off 20 Oct 2026 · NERAI

7 · The escalation ladder

> **0 · Today: blockade and tanker war.** US blockade of Iranian ports; IRGC attacks and mining claims in and around Hormuz; Houthi–Saudi war; talks via Qatar and Pakistan. Tripwire: a mass-casualty hit on US forces or a sinking with heavy loss of life.

> **1 · Short strike round (NERAI: November).** A few days of US–Israeli strikes on energy, buried nuclear and missile targets. Analogs: 22 June 2025 strikes on Fordow, Natanz and Isfahan; the September 2026 strike cycle. Off-ramp: a declared end of operations plus an offer through Doha.

> **2 · Horizontal retaliation (likely, days 1–5).** Iranian fire on Israel, US bases and Gulf energy and digital sites. Analogs: April and October 2024 salvos on Israel; the March 2026 strike on Ras Laffan. Off-ramp: US restraint on follow-on strikes; Gulf pressure on both sides.

> **3 · Two-strait closure attempt (plausible).** Full Hormuz closure attempt with mines and swarms; Houthis close the Red Sea to Western-linked shipping. Analog: the 2024 Red Sea campaign at Hormuz scale. Off-ramp: the Hormuz-for-blockade swap.

> **4 · Nuclear threshold (tail).** NPT withdrawal notice or evidence of weaponisation work; a US raid on uranium sites or regime-targeting strikes. Analog: none in this war; January 2020 (Soleimani) shows how a decapitation strike can end in a telegraphed, contained reply. Off-ramp: uranium exported to a third country under IAEA supervision.

Tripwires: what to watch, and what it would mean

Indicator	Now	If it lights
A third US carrier on station; airlift into Gulf bases; tanker aircraft surges	building	Strike window open within days
Ordered departures from US missions beyond Saudi Arabia	Saudi Arabia only (22 Oct) [10]	Final preparation phase
NOTAMs closing Iraqi, Syrian or Jordanian airspace corridors	not lit	Strike routes in use
Iran's parliament votes the NPT bill; IAEA Board escalates	bill pending	Nuclear rung moves up
Qatar or Pakistan announce a round of direct talks	indirect only	Strike delay; interim deal window
Houthi strikes on non-Saudi Western ships	not lit	Red Sea joins Hormuz; Suez return reverses
Hezbollah heavy rocket fire on northern Israel	not lit	Israeli second front; longer round

What it means for decision-makers

- **Shipping and energy.** Plan for a strike week in the second half of November: hold Gulf-bound cargoes outside the Gulf of Oman during that window, expect war-risk cover to be repriced at short notice, and assume the Red Sea return pauses.
- **People and sites.** The US has ordered non-emergency staff out of Saudi Arabia [10]; Saudi Arabia, the UAE and Bahrain host the highest-value targets. Review shelter and evacuation plans for staff near energy, port and data-centre sites.
- **Compliance.** NERAI's sanctions reading for Iran is high for the coming month: screen counterparties, ship-to-ship transfer partners and payment routes.
- **Markets.** Price a short spike, not a regime change: NERAI's base case returns to blockade and talks by January.

Method and sources

NERAI Question Report pipeline (generic question-to-report, live since 23 Oct 2026) on the pairs US–Iran, Israel–Iran and Saudi Arabia–Iran and on Iran's domestic and sanctions outlook; NERAI event forecasts (model set event-live-v9, as of 23 Oct 2026; only benchmark-passing forecasts named); NERAI pair readings and risk calendar (P10); NERAI analysis of The GDELT Project CAMEO events (gdeltproject.org) to 22 Oct 2026; NERAI Sentinel-1 SAR vessel presence (contains modified Copernicus Sentinel data 2025–2026); NERAI corridor status rule with dated public observations; U.S. EIA Brent spot. Dated public reporting below, opened and read on 23 Oct 2026.

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